

Optionally, at a lesser price range you have the Creative PC Works 2.1, the Samsung SMS 8320 or again the Typhoon Silver Crest 400. These systems manage to deliver the right punch and flavours that can engross any gamer in those fierce *Unreal Tournament*.

The Samsung, although less powerful, delivers ample amount of sound effects required to play high-end multiplayer games. However, in terms of power the Lexpro LS880 can be graded as more powerful than the Samsung, but here the quality of the sound delivered is bad. There is a lot of jarring and distortion audible in Lexpro LS880, especially while playing *Quake III Arena*, but this was considerably less while playing *Unreal Tournament*.

Music

In this field, the **Samsung SMS 8230** took the overall lead with its clarity in vocals and the perfect treble response. It was able to maintain the overall quality of bass reproduction. The speaker that came second was the Typhoon Silver Crest 400 and it did quite well too, but lagged behind in bass reproduction. Next in line was Creative PC Works. It lacked the overall clarity that was found in the Samsung SMS 8230, but the set had exceptional bass reproduction.

The Funai-788 was no stranger to music and was capable enough to deliver good quality sound with decent bass and mid response. The only problem that was found here was in the treble, which was too

When you go in to buy a speaker or a music system, one thing you must look out for is the output (power) of the product. Power rating in the sound industry is measured using two different terminologies—PMPO (Peak Music Power Output) and RMS (Root Mean Square Power). This displays the different rating systems that are in use for obtaining the output capacity of a specific speaker or amplifier. A common misapprehension is that higher the PMPO rating of the speaker, the better the output and quality of the speaker or system as a whole. Actually, it's the RMS rating that determines quality and higher the RMS rating, better the speakers.

What do PMPO and RMS refer to?
PMPO refers to the maximum amount of

power that the speaker or the amplifier can deliver at its peak. A PMPO rating is not necessarily indicative of the performance of a speaker throughout a wide frequency range. An RMS power value is the actual music power output of a speaker. It is a true indication of the output power of a given speaker and its ability to generate sounds having frequencies throughout a wider range.

The continuous output is a better indicator of power and this is what you should look for when comparing speaker systems. So the general rule adopted by serious music lovers and audiophiles is that higher the true RMS rating of a speaker, higher is its actual power or volume output. Remember the rule, 'Greater the RMS rating, better the speakers'.

loud and at certain points where there is a mish mash of frequencies, a bit of distortion was noticed. But otherwise it would definitely qualify for music playback.

Surround speakers

Here, we concentrated on speaker systems that offer surround sound and this included the 4.1 and the 5.1 sets. Surround sound refers to the use of multiple channels to envelop the movie-watching or music-listening audience, making them feel like they're in the middle of the action

or concert. True surround sound algorithms rely on dedicated speakers that physically surround the audience. There is one centre speaker, which carries most of the dialogue and part of the soundtrack. There are left and right front speakers that carry most of the soundtrack and may carry parts of the dialogue. Then there is a pair of surround sound speakers that is placed to the side of the audience to provide the surround sound effect. Finally, a subwoofer can be used to reproduce the low frequency bass effect.

In this category, we received seven different brands of speakers. Creative has always had a major presence in this segment, but lately there have been quite a few other manufactures such as Logitech who are giving Creative some serious competition. Special mention must be made of Jetway, which has produced the small wonder called Artis. And its pricing is aggressive too. Others like Frontech have also made a significant splash in this segment.

Quality

In terms of surround quality, the speaker that emerges as the best is the **Creative Cambridge SoundWorks DTT2500** that acquired the highest scores in the quality section. Here the best part was the setup that we received—a Dolby Digital decoder that allows you to enjoy stunning DVD audio without purchasing an expensive Dolby Digital system. The decoder is equipped with Dolby 5.1-channel that pumps sound into the front left, front

Headphones or Earphones?

Earphones? They are uncomfortable to wear, sound tinny and they harm your ears. If you have ever bought a portable audio device, it probably came with this pain in the ear. Cheap earphones aren't even remotely suited for playing music or any kind of hi fidelity audio. Do you want deeper bass, crisper highs, clear mid tones? Then consider buying a good pair of headphones. They come in a wide variety, starting from simple, cheap Rs 50 headsets to the swank looking Philips headphones that are sold for around Rs 700. The latter offers a higher degree of comfort with its foam ear pads and adjustable headrests, and offers nice bass and mid tones. Though not the perfect set, it's enough to satisfy most regular audio lovers.

But if you're a real audio freak and nothing less than the very best can satisfy you, then brands such as Sennheiser, Koss or AKG low-end headphones may be what you should opt for. These headphones cost in the range of Rs 1,500 to Rs 4,000. If you are wondering why we said low-end, the reason is simple. Your PC just isn't capable of driving high-end headphones. You would need something called a headphone amplifier to drive the likes of the Rs 5,000 to Rs 20,000 headphones that are nothing less than 'super phones' when it comes to quality and reproduction accuracy. And they are loud enough for DJs who use them in environments full of noise, and still manage to hear that fine skip or beat that helps them synch their own mixes.